

**BEFORE THE PUBLIC UTILITIES COMMISSION
OF THE STATE OF CALIFORNIA**

Order Instituting Rulemaking to
Modernize the Electric Grid for a High
Distributed Energy Resources Future.

Rulemaking 21-06-017
(Filed June 24, 2021)

**REPLY COMMENTS OF THE VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL ON THE
PROPOSED DECISION ADOPTING IMPROVEMENTS TO DISTRIBUTION
PLANNING AND PROJECT EXECUTION PROCESS, DISTRIBUTION RESOURCE
PLANNING DATA PORTALS, AND INTEGRATION CAPACITY ANALYSIS MAPS**

Zach Woogen
Interim Executive Director
VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL
10265 Rockingham Dr.
Suite#100-4061
Sacramento, California 95827
Telephone: (510) 665-7811
Email: vgicregulatory@vgicouncil.org

Date: October 8, 2024

**BEFORE THE PUBLIC UTILITIES COMMISSION
OF THE STATE OF CALIFORNIA**

Order Instituting Rulemaking to
Modernize the Electric Grid for a High
Distributed Energy Resources Future.

Rulemaking 21-06-017
(Filed June 24, 2021)

**REPLY COMMENTS OF THE VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL ON THE
PROPOSED DECISION ADOPTING IMPROVEMENTS TO DISTRIBUTION
PLANNING AND PROJECT EXECUTION PROCESS, DISTRIBUTION RESOURCE
PLANNING DATA PORTALS, AND INTEGRATION CAPACITY ANALYSIS MAPS**

In accordance with the Rules of Practice and Procedure of the California Public Utilities Commission (“Commission”), the Vehicle-Grid Integration Council (“VGIC”) hereby submits these reply comments on the *Proposed Decision Adopting Improvements to Distribution Planning and Project Execution Process, Distribution Resource Planning Data Portals, and Integration Capacity Analysis Maps* (“PD”) issued by Commissioner Houck on September 13, 2024.

I. INTRODUCTION.

As expressed in Opening Comments by VGIC and other parties, California must take concrete steps to improve distribution planning for new load growth, and the PD takes many important steps towards achieving this goal. At the same time, the major changes identified in the PD will require years of implementation, and the additional distribution investments will lead to large increases in cost. Therefore, the Commission should seek to expand solutions in the near-term to add additional off-peak load and should seek to unlock optimal amounts of load flexibility in the longer-term, especially from electric vehicles (“EV”). With these goals in mind, VGIC offers the following replies to party comments:

- VGIC agrees with other parties that the Commission should create widespread flexible service connection offerings.
- VGIC agrees with other parties recommending that stakeholder feedback should be taken on the scope of the Part 2 Electrification Impact Study and Load Flexibility Assessment.

II. THE COMMISSION SHOULD CREATE WIDESPREAD FLEXIBLE SERVICE CONNECTION OFFERINGS.

Multiple parties, including Advanced Energy United (“United”), California Community Choice Association (“CalCCA”), CALSTART, Environmental Defense Fund (“EDF”), and Natural Resources Defense Council (“NRDC”), commented on the importance of flexible service connections in allowing customers to get energized more quickly and at a lower cost and noted that the Commission should take broader action on this issue to scale flexible service connections.¹ EDF and NRDC note that “Limiting solutions like flexible service connections to be pilots or one-off narrow programs will inevitably lead to lower uptake and fewer benefits for individual customers and ratepayers as a whole.”² Parties also highlight that while flexible service connections are beneficial bridging solutions for temporary energization, they can also be scaled to provide permanent operating parameters to reduce costs for customers and ratepayers.³ VGIC agrees that these solutions are scalable for bridging and long-term uses and we agree with parties that Finding of Fact #14, stating that scalable solutions for evaluation do not exist, should be deleted or modified to acknowledge that scalable solutions can be developed in the future.⁴ The

¹ See Advanced Energy United (“United”) Opening Comments at 3-5; California Community Choice Association (“CalCCA”) Opening Comments at 6-7; CALSTART Opening Comments at 5-7; Environmental Defense Fund (“EDF”) and Natural Resources Defense Council (“NRDC”) Opening Comments at 4-5.

² EDF and NRDC Opening Comments at 5.

³ United Opening Comments at 4; CalCCA Opening Comments at 7; CALSTART Opening Comments at 5-6; EDF and NRDC Opening Comments at 5.

⁴ Parties with this recommendation include United and CalCCA.

PD directs utilities to file a singular compliance filing on their current plans in December, with no follow-up venues for feedback or discussion. This limitation represents a barrier to the development of broader solutions.

VGIC acknowledges that many elements need clarification to scale broader flexible service connections. As highlighted by CALSTART, scaling flexible service connections will require rules around the energization study analysis, contractual obligations for the utility or customer, potential override and compensation mechanisms, third-party power control system integrations and standards, and the tariff modifications required to implement all of these provisions.⁵ The motion by Enphase referenced by VGIC in our opening comments also discusses the development of more standardized Limited Load Profiles that would allow for firm import limit schedules and additional dynamic, non-firm imports.⁶ However, the Enphase motion makes clear that the Commission will need to take action to develop these options.⁷

The Commission could evaluate a variety of scalable flexible service connection solutions if a procedural venue is opened for their development and discussion. United and CALSTART recommend that the Commission adopt a recommendation made by Cal Advocates for the utilities to file a Tier 2 Advice Letter on their bridging strategies and to follow-up during the annual DPAG meetings.⁸ Enphase's motions have proposed to add scoping questions around flexible service connections to existing regulatory proceedings, which would allow the Commission to develop a record to evaluate scalable solutions. VGIC is open to addressing these issues through either a Rulemaking or an Advice Letter process, but we believe that either process should allow for

⁵ CALSTART Opening Comments at 7.

⁶ *Motion of Enphase Energy, Inc. to Amend Scoping Ruling and Schedule to Address Optional Flexible Connection Agreements and the Underwriters' Laboratory 3141 Standard for Power Control Systems in Investor-owned Utilities' Energization Rules* filed by Enphase Energy in R.24-01-018 on September 11, 2024.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ United Opening Comments at 4; CALSTART Opening Comments at 6.

stakeholder feedback and discussion to ensure the resulting rules and regulations are well-fit to customer needs. **Regardless of pathway, the most important action the Commission can take is to identify and start the next steps for scaling these solutions now.**

III. STAKEHOLDER FEEDBACK SHOULD BE TAKEN THE SCOPE OF THE PART 2 ELECTRIFICATION IMPACT STUDY AND LOAD FLEXIBILITY ASSESSMENT.

The Commission should clarify the scope, roles, and timelines for the EIS Part 2 Study and associated Load Flexibility Assessment. In Opening Comments, multiple parties commented on the confusion on the full scope of the study and the roles and responsibilities of different entities such as the utilities, Kevala, and the California Energy Commission (“CEC”). The PD references the “Electrification Impact Study Part 2 *currently* being conducted by Utilities, [*emphasis added*]”⁹ and states that the study “is on track to begin in the near term,”¹⁰ implying that the scope of the study has already been decided. However, San Diego Gas and Electric (“SDG&E”) states that “the scope and timeline for the Utilities’ EIS Part 2 studies are still being developed.”¹¹ United and Utility Consumers’ Action Network (“UCAN”) highlight that the Commission has never formally indicated that the utilities would be developing the Part 2 study and reference previous Commission Rulings and the EIS Part 1 study that suggest that Kevala would be conducting the Part 2 study.¹² SDG&E also highlights that the CEC is creating a Demand Flexibility (DF) Resource Potential tool that could be incorporated into the EIS Part 2 study, Load Flexibility Study, or other future studies.¹³ This has led to uncertainty as to what will be included in the Part 2 study

⁹ PD at 90.

¹⁰ PD at 95.

¹¹ SDG&E Opening Comments at 5.

¹² United Opening Comments at 5-8; UCAN Opening Comments at 2-6.

¹³ SDG&E Opening Comments at 5-6.

and the timeframe when this study will be conducted. The Commission should clarify these elements in the final decision.

The Commission should also take additional stakeholder feedback on the scope of the Part 2 study. For example, in Opening Comments, VGIC recommended that the Part 2 Study include different electric vehicle managed charging scenarios (i.e., including a low, medium, and high V1G scenario, as well as a V2X bidirectional charging scenario) and to consider the potential for software- and hardware-based solutions to manage EV charging load specifically for local grid constraints. However, the PD does not propose to allow for any additional stakeholder feedback on the Part 2 Study until it is already complete. The EIS Part 1 Study allowed for significant stakeholder engagement to develop the scope and process for that study, which led to the study providing more important insights on bottom-up forecasting, needed distribution upgrades, and cost insights. This stakeholder engagement should be done for the Part 2 study as well. As such, VGIC supports United's recommendation that the PD "be revised to align with the Staff Proposal and allow for stakeholder comment on the EIS Part 2 and Flexible Load DPP Assessment."¹⁴

IV. CONCLUSION.

VGIC appreciates the opportunity to provide these reply comments on the Proposed Decision. We look forward to further collaboration with the Commission and stakeholders on this initiative.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Zach Woogen

Zach Woogen

Interim Executive Director

¹⁴ United Opening Comments at 8.

VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL

Date: October 8, 2024